St Helena

World's oldest tortoise caught in viral crypto death scam

Fake X account posing as his vet sparked global false reports of Jonathan's death while soliciting crypto donations

Jonathan, the world's oldest tortoise, has lived through the Victorian period and two world wars. Photograph: Saint Helena/PA

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At 194 years old, Jonathan the giant tortoise was a youngster when Queen Victoria ascended to the throne - and has now lived long enough to fall victim to a crypto scam.

News outlets including the BBC, Daily Mail and USA Today falsely reported his death after an X account posing as Jonathan's vet broke the news.

The post, attributed to "Joe Hollins", claimed: "Heartbroken to share that our beloved Jonathan, the world's oldest living land animal, has passed away today peacefully on Saint Helena.

"As his vet for many years, it was an honour to care for him - hand-feeding bananas, watching him bask in the sun and marvelling at his quiet wisdom. He leaves behind a legacy of resilience and longevity that inspired millions. Rest easy, old friend. You'll be missed more than words can say."

The real Joe Hollins with Jonathan. Photograph: Saint Helena/PA

Though the post received 2m views and was reported as fact by the UK's national broadcaster, checks by the Guardian revealed the account was based in Brazil. The real vet, who does not use X, said: "Jonathan the tortoise is very much alive. I believe on X the person purporting to be me is asking for crypto donations, so it's not even an April fool joke. It's a con."

The impostor was indeed asking for cryptocurrency donations at the time the BBC published - and later retracted - its report.

Jonathan, a Seychelles giant tortoise, is the world's oldest known land animal. He has lived on the grounds of the governor's mansion on Saint Helena, since 1882, when he arrived as a gift to the South Atlantic island.

Members of the royal family, including King George VI, Queen Elizabeth II (then known as Princess Elizabeth), Princess Margaret, and the Queen Mother (the then Queen Elizabeth) on Saint Helena, meeting Jonathan in 1947. Photograph: Saint Helena/PA

Nigel Phillips, the governor, was getting ready for bed on Wednesday night when he was inundated with anxious messages. He got up and searched the grounds to check on the tortoise. "Jonathan is asleep under a tree in the paddock," he told the Guardian, adding that the animal was "very much alive".

On Thursday morning, Phillips joked that Jonathan had issued a press statement: "The report of my death was an exaggeration ... Mark Twain, not Oscar Wilde. Jonathan would nonetheless have had the chance enjoy both their works in the original first editions."

Despite being blind from cataracts and having lost his sense of smell, Jonathan remains hale and hearty with a strong appetite for bananas and a healthy libido - he tries to mate with two younger tortoises who also reside on the governor's property.

Jonathan next to a BBC news page on an iPad as proof of life on Thursday morning. Photograph: Nigel Phillips

The governor's team trudged out into the rain on Thursday morning to take a picture of the sleepy-looking tortoise, who had just woken up from an 11-hour slumber. The twice-weekly local paper would not be out until later that day, so in lieu of that they posed the tortoise with an iPad showing the BBC homepage as proof of life.

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Lying on the ground, slightly shrouded in shrubbery, Jonathan seemed oblivious to the global furore caused by the false news of his death. His shell was glimmering from the morning rain. He is likely to be in a bad mood; the tortoise much prefers sunshine, in which he basks with limbs stretched out and eyes half-closed.

The scam has rocked the community on the small island of approximately 4,440 people, where the tortoise is a local celebrity who has appeared on the reverse of St Helena's 5p coin.

Phillips shed some light on the tortoise's long life: "Jonathan's day is mostly spent grazing on grass. One day a week he is fed fruit, veg and salad to ensure he gets essential minerals. He has a sweet tooth. Tourists occasionally come to view him, but that is carefully managed to ensure the animals are not stressed.

"Beyond that, there really is not much more to say about his daily routine. Perhaps the simplicity is the key to his longevity!"

The hoax had a happy ending for Jonathan, who was given a double helping of his favourite snack of bananas in celebration of his resurrection. He was seen enthusiastically munching the chopped-up fruit from the hand of one of his keepers.

The real Hollins was momentarily worried about the fake news spread by his impersonator; the islanders are genuinely dreading the day Jonathan dies. He told the Guardian: "It makes one slightly nervous considering he's at least 194."

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